

REQUEST FOR INFORMATION (RFI)

DISCLAIMER:

This notice is issued solely for market research, planning, and information-gathering purposes in accordance with FAR Part 10 (Market Research). It is not a competitive solicitation, request for proposals (RFP), request for quotations (RFQ), invitation for bids (IFB), or commitment by the issuing entity to issue a solicitation or award a contract. The Government does not intend to award a contract on the basis of the RFI or otherwise pay for the information requested and responses will be treated as information only and not as a proposal. The Government will not reimburse for responses to this RFI. Responses to this notice will be used to:

- Assess the availability of commercial products or services that meet or can be modified to meet the requirement.
- Determine the capabilities of interested sources, including small businesses (e.g., small business, veteran-owned small business, service-disabled veteran-owned small business, HUBZone, 8(a), women-owned small business).
- Inform the acquisition strategy, including whether a set-aside, partial set-aside, or full-and-open competition is appropriate, or if other than full-and-open competition may be justified.

The North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) for this requirement is 541714 – Research and Development in Biotechnology (except Nanobiotechnology); and the Product and Service Code is Q301 – Reference Laboratory Testing.

BACKGROUND:

Vector-borne diseases transmitted by arthropods, such as dengue and malaria, continue to pose significant threats to U.S. military forces, particularly in deployed and austere environments. The Theater Preventive Medicine Flight conducts surveillance of arthropods to detect human pathogens and supports quality assurance programs that ensure the accuracy and reliability of diagnostic testing.

Given the complexity of insect vectors and the pathogens they carry, a rigorous quality assurance program is required for producing reliable results that inform public health decision-making. External Quality Assurance (EQA) programs—also known as proficiency testing—involve laboratories periodically testing unknown samples provided by a third party. This process independently verifies diagnostic capabilities and identifies areas for improvement.

There is a need to develop external quality tests that utilize non-infectious agents. This approach minimizes risk while enabling broader implementation as part of a multi-layered framework of good laboratory practices, standardized protocols, and external validation.

SCOPE:

The scope of work is limited to the research, development, validation, and documentation of safe external proficiency testing procedures as described in the high-level objectives below. Work shall be performed exclusively at the contractor's laboratory facilities. The Government will

provide limited virus-free mosquito samples for use in confirmation testing. The contractor is not required to collect samples or perform testing of operational/field-collected arthropod pools.

OBJECTIVES:

- 1) Develop a Written Manual/Protocol for Safe External Proficiency Testing
- 2) Validate the Proficiency Testing Protocol
- 3) Demonstrate Proficiency Test Performance Characteristics
- 4) Provide Analysis of Field-Expedient Capability

REQUESTED INFORMATION:

If your organization has the potential capacity, experience and knowledge to perform the required services, please provide a white paper (limited to 10 pages) with sufficient information to ensure that respondents can successfully perform to and fulfill all requirements. The following shall be addressed in white paper submissions:

1. Company Information:

- Organization name, address, email address, website (if available), telephone number.
- Business size and type of ownership (e.g., large business, small business, veteran-owned small business, service-disabled veteran-owned, HUBZone, 8(a), women-owned, etc.).
- UEI number (from SAM.gov) and CAGE code.

2. Capability Details:

- A description of past performance performing these same or similar requirements. Please provide the previous Government contract number (if applicable) and who received the services (Government, research facility or educational facility).
- Any limitations, proprietary aspects, or unique features that may impact the performance and completion of this requirement.
- Provide a brief description demonstrating your organization's ability and knowledge to perform the required services.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION:

Submission Deadline – Refer to the applicable SAM.gov posting for the exact deadline.

All questions and responses under this RFI must be submitted via email to the Contract Specialist at Benjamin.t.marcus2.civ@health.mil.

Telephone inquiries will not be accepted or acknowledged. No feedback or evaluations will be provided to companies regarding submissions (except for a confirmation email acknowledging receipt). Late responses may not be acknowledged. Responses will be reviewed for planning purposes only. Proprietary or confidential information should be clearly marked.